

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J T 8 7

♥ 6 5 4

♦ Q J 3

♣ K 4

♠ 9 3 2

♥ A J 7

♦ A 4

♣ Q J 8 7 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 6 5

♥ Q 9 8 2

♦ T 8 7 6 2

♣ 5

♠ K 4

♥ K T 3

♦ K 9 5

♣ A T 9 6 2

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
1 ♠	2 ♠	Pass	3 ♣
Pass	5 ♣		
All Pass			
5 ♣ by South			

North's cue-bid shows a limit raise or better (11 points) in ♣s. South is to play 5♣. West leads the ♠Q, East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠6 to your ♠K.

You have lost one trick already and have a possible loser in trumps and another possible loser in ♥s. Both losers can be avoided with successful finesses. The problem with the ♣ finesse is that West made an overcall so he is more likely to hold the ♣K. If you don't try the ♣ finesse you may be able to throw a defender in with the ♣K at a time when he will have to help you with his next play.

After winning the ♠K immediately play the ♣A.

It would have been nice to see the ♣K fall, but it didn't. So play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A and play the ♠9, ruffing in your hand.

Eliminate the ♦s by playing ♦K, then ruffing your last ♦ in dummy.

You have done all the eliminating, time to throw in somebody. Play a ♣.

Whichever defender had the ♣K is now on lead, but wishes he wasn't. If he plays a ♥ you get a free finesse. If he plays anything else you get a ruff-sluff.

If you had finessed for the ♣K West would have won the trick and been able to make a safe exit, probably with his other ♣.

You would then have been forced to rely on the ♥ finesse, and with West being the defender who showed some strength, you would likely have finessed through him.

About the only way the elimination/throw-in could fail is if the ♣s split 3-0. Then, if you play Ace and another the defender who wins would use his third ♣ as a safe exit.

Board 2

West Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q T 3

♥ 2

♦ T 8 7 2

♣ K J 5 4

♠ A 8 6 2

♥ A T 9 6

♦ A K

♣ 7 6 3



♠ J 9 7 4

♥ 8

♦ J 9 6 4 3

♣ 9 8 2

♠ 5

♥ K Q J 7 5 4 3

♦ Q 5

♣ A Q T

West	North	East	South
Pass	1NT	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥	Pass	5♣
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by South

Conveniently in dummy, you play a ♣ and insert the ♣T if East plays low.

[showcards N:HA,H6,C7,C6 S:HK,HQ,CA,CQ]

West will probably win this trick. If he wins with the ♣K then your hand is good. If he wins with the ♣J then he is end-played, forced to either lead a ♣ into your ♣ A Q or to give you a ruff-sluff.

You probably noticed that you could have finessed your ♣Q on the first ♣ play and pulled off the end-play just as effectively. But there is an advantage to making the first finesse with the ♣T.

If East just happens to hold both the ♣K and ♣J you will make all thirteen tricks if your first finesse is with the ♣T!

Your 3♥ bid is a slam suggestion. After you show the ♣A partner wastes no time in bidding it.

South is to play 6♥. West leads the ♠K.

This is a good slam. You have only two possible ♣ losers, and by taking two ♣ finesses you have an excellent chance of success. But by using an elimination play you will have a sure thing.

Win the ♠A and ruff a ♠ with a ♥ honor.

Play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9 and ruff another ♠. Both defenders followed to the trump play.

Play another ♥ to dummy's ♥10 and ruff the last ♠.

Play the ♦A and ♦K.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q 2
 ♥ K 9 7 2
 ♦ K 7 5 3
 ♣ T 3

♠ J T 7

♥ 8 6 5

♦ A 6 2

♣ A Q 8 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 8 5 4 3

♥ J 4 3

♦ J T 9

♣ 9 6 2

♠ A 9 6

♥ A Q T

♦ Q 8 4

♣ K J 7 5

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

trick in the suit.) West wins with the ♠ Q, and guess what?

HE IS ENDPLAYED!. He has no ♣s, and whichever other suit he plays will give you your ninth trick!

Wow! End-played at trick #6.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥ 2. East plays the ♥ J which you win with the ♥ Q.

You have one trick already in the bag, four more to come in ♣s, and three other Aces. So all you have to do is get one of those finesse positions to come through. By now, though, you must have figured that nothing is going to work! Even your best shot, East holding at least one of ♠ K Q will not happen. The answer (again) is to eliminate, then throw in.

This time there is only one suit you can eliminate, ♣s. So play all four ♣s, ending in dummy. They split 3-2.

You now play the ♠ J from dummy and let it ride when East follows with a low card. (If East had covered you would win the Ace then set up a second

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 8 3
♥ J T 8 4
♦ K T 6 2
♣ T 2

♠ A T 7 2

♥ 9 6

♦ J 5 4

♣ Q J 9 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 9 4

♥ Q 7 5 3 2

♦ A 9 3

♣ 8 6 3

♠ K J 6 5

♥ A K

♦ Q 8 7

♣ A K 7 4

West	North	East	South
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			
4♠ by South			

South is to play 4♠ after North's Stayman bid uncovered the 4-4 fit. West leads the ♥J which you win the your ♥A.

With three possible losers in ♦s you might first think that you will have to finesse one of the defenders for the trump Queen. But anytime you see an unsupported Jack opposite an unsupported Queen you should start thinking about a throw-in play. And what better card to use for the throw-in than the Queen of trumps.

So pull two rounds of trumps with the ♠A and ♠K, hoping the ♠Q falls. She doesn't fall, but both defenders do follow suit. So the ♠Q is the only trump outstanding.

Next eliminate ♥s from you and dummy by playing the ♥K.

Now play four rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit. If a defender decides to ruff one of these ♣s with the master trump he will be end-played, forced to either play a ♦ or to give you a ruff-sluff. So assume that all four ♣s win tricks.

Now you administer the coup de gras, you lead a trump.

[showcards N:ST,DJ,D5,D4 S:SJ,DQ,D8,D7]

One of the defenders has won the ♠Q. Too bad for him. If he now plays a ♦ you will make either the ♦Q or ♦J. If he plays a ♥ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♦ loser from the other.

It is clear that the elimination play saved you having to guess the finesse for the ♠Q.

But what if you considered yourself a really good guesser? So good that you felt confident in taking the finesse, and so good that you pulled it off successfully.

You'd be no better off. Although you would avoid the ♠ loser you would now have to play the ♦s for yourself and you would lose three ♦s!

Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J T 9 7 2
 ♥ K T 7 4
 ♦ Q 8 2
 ♣ 7

♠ Q 5

♥ A J 6 2

♦ A 9 6 4

♣ A J 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 8 6 3

♥ Q 9 8 3

♦ T 7 5

♣ 8 2

♠ A 4

♥ 5

♦ K J 3

♣ K Q T 9 6 4 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	4♣	Pass	6♣
All Pass			
6♣ by South			

South considered Blackwood, then realized if North showed either 2 or 3 Aces he was going to bid slam. But if North showed just one Ace he would have to maneuver to play 5NT which might be worse than 6♣. So he just bid the slam. South plays 6♣. West leads the ♠J.

You wish, you hope, you may even pray, but when you play the ♠Q East covers with the ♠K. So you know you have a ♠ loser. And unless East holds the ♦Q you might have a ♦ loser also.

Perhaps an elimination play will improve your chances. Don't lead a trump yet though, you're going to need several entries to dummy to eliminate the ♥s.

Win the ♠, play to the ♥A and ruff a ♥.

Play a trump to dummy's ♣J (both defenders follow) and ruff another ♥ high.

Play to dummy's ♣A, pulling their last trump, and ruff the last ♥.

Now execute the throw-in by leading a ♠. If West wins the trick he will have to play ♦s for you or give you a ruff-sluff. So if these are competent defenders they will make sure that it is **EAST** who wins the ♠ trick. So he does, and he plays a small ♦.

DO NOT PLAY THE JACK! If the finesse is going to work now it will still work one trick later. By playing low you take advantage of the possibility that East held the ♦10 and West will have to put on the ♦Q to prevent you taking a trick with dummy's ♦9.

Many elimination endings give you a sure thing. Others just improve your chances.

Here you had two chances. First, West might have HAD to win the throw-in, either because he had all of the high ♠s, or more likely because he messed up. The second chance paid off when East took the throw-in but you found a fortunate position with the ♦s.